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On a Whym: The marketing mavens behind Spectacles launch a 'text boutique'

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Over the course of her career, tech marketing executive [Kelly Nyland](#) has helped launch the Parrot AR.Drone, Sphero robot toys, and Snap Inc's. Spectacles.

Now she and her co-founder, [Rhenee Bartlett](#), are launching a company of their own: Whym, a "text boutique" offering products geared toward professional women via the mode they often use to communicate — text.

The El Segundo, California-based startup, built out of the team's text-commerce floral delivery business Petalfox, launched on Nov. 1.

Here's how Whym works: A consumer signs up by texting 95479. Then a Whym (pronounced "whim") employee texts back in real time with shopping options that the consumer responds to using emojis. Pictures and links within the text conversation enable the customer to see exactly what is available in the lookbook.

When a customer selects a desired product, she texts a predetermined hashtag and checks out using her secure Whym Wallet. Shipping and payment information is collected during the first purchase only and products are delivered within two to five days. All future purchases happen entirely over text message, eliminating the need to remember a password or credit card PIN.



CAN AHTAM

Whym offers products geared toward professional women via the mode they most often use to communicate — text.

Whym's products include desk accessories, office supplies, flowers, coffee, tea, sweets, natural care, sexual wellness and room fragrances curated from niche "instabrand" with fewer than 30,000 social media followers that offer high-quality, easily replenishable products and appeal to women by focusing on ethics, wellness and taking their bodies into consideration. Whym's strategy is to offer unique products to customers while supporting the success of small online brands.

"Many companies are starting to explore text message as a means of marketing, but we've built a fully functional text boutique complete with frictionless payments, a full product offering and a one-on-one customer concierge," Nyland said in a [statement](#) upon the company's launch earlier this month.

Nyland, who serves as CEO, and Barlett, who is COO, first met at Snap, where they orchestrated the Cannes Lions award-winning launch of Spectacles in 2016 with a playful advertising campaign and pop-up kiosks.

They bootstrapped what became Whym for the first 10 months, then raised a couple of pre-seed rounds from Kate McAndrew and Greg McAdoo at Bolt and Charles Hudson at Precursor Ventures, as well as a New York-based fund and an angel investment from Canaan Partners.

Their team now comprises fewer than 10 full-time employees serving tens of thousands of active users.

Nyland expanded on Whym via email, including what inspired the launch of the company, the future of text commerce and the most important thing she brought with her from Snap (NYSE: SNAP).

What inspired Whym, and why is it needed?

Whym was born out of a desire to bring a personal touch back into the shopping experience, as it has existed within brands for centuries.

As a busy, working mother of a 9-year-old son, I often don't make a lot of time for self-care. I noticed that my small "happy spends" were a way for me to make micro-investments in my mental health. I came to realize that most e-commerce and retail experiences remain unnecessarily agnostic, when we now have more data than ever to access on behalf of our customers.

We are building a team that makes things easier and more convenient for our customers during their purchase experience. We remove the guesswork from finding and getting (or

gifting!) great items and focus on products from women-founded companies and businesses with shared, niche brand values.

Our founding idea was simple. Curate products that have a natural replenishment cycle and meet our customers in a place that has their highest attention — over text message — and offer them a quick, binary option: Would you like to order or skip?

How does Whym build on your previous text commerce business, Petalfox?

Petalfox is dedicated to replenishing self-purchased flowers. As we looked at consumable "goods," we were curious about underserved market potential within the floral industry. Over 51 percent of purchases in this \$7.5 billion dollar industry are made by women for themselves. This impulse buy happens most frequently at the grocery store, since a digital experience had not been tailored for this behavior, until Petalfox. Petalfox is now an entire floral-inspired collection under Whym.

Flowers were, ironically, a perfect place for us to start. We have a streamlined business model which allowed us to build a strong operational and logistics foundation, as well as focus on a backend technical stack that enables a best-in-class consumer experience. In our research of more than 35 of the 160 "messaging software" platforms available in the industry, we found that a solution for personalized-commerce-over-text-message had not yet been imagined in the way we've built it.

New customers create a secure wallet during their first purchase experience. All future purchases are made without an account password, needing to find a purse, reentering payment info or a credit card PIN. Our customers champion the addiction of this purchase behavior and regularly send us feedback about what other products they "wish they could buy this way."

Enter Whym.

Whym is our new parent company. Petalfox is now an expanded "floral collection" under Whym which includes floral prints, faux flowers and more items to celebrate an everyday romance with yourself.

The company not only allows us to operate under a broader narrative, but introduces an entire retail ecosystem powered by text-commerce including text-message commerce, e-commerce with checkout over text, shop-by-text in our physical lookbook mailer, and pop-up shop-by-text for this holiday in retail footprints in Los Angeles. In each of these four retail or merchandising channels, customers can create a virtual cart from any online or offline experience and check out via text. This text ecosystem brings together the best of e-com and in-store shopping, creating a "space" and a purpose for the mobile phone.

What market does Whym target, and how big is it?

We target women who are doing most of their shopping online. While this market is used to the traditional online shopping methods of today's world, through our platform, we want to reinvent what they think of traditional e-commerce.

You'll find that most investors roll their eyes if you don't find a "realistic" market to tackle, meaning it can't be too big or too little. But the online shopping industry is huge — and it's still growing.

Through research, we found that in 2018, there were 258.9 million digital buyers in the United States and by 2023, there are projected to be over 307 million buyers reaching over 90 percent of internet users. Additionally, the U.S. internet retail industry is expected to reach \$523 billion, which is leaving us with a huge market opportunity to enter the e-commerce playing field. Through Whym, we have the opportunity to bring all of these consumers a simpler way to get what they want.

As of 2017, women dominated the online shopping industry, which is why our text-to-shop platform currently sells products from the floral, food and beverage, beauty and other career-focused female categories. All of the products sold through Whym's text commerce platform directly target this massive retail market. Right now, we are offering unique products that have been meticulously curated from a variety of "instabrand." Now, thanks to Whym, customers can shop the brands they see on Instagram but can't touch or feel anywhere else.

Whym targets women who crave a new kind of personal interaction. The powerful female who doesn't have time to wander through a store or search the FAQ page online. Whym targets the woman who wants it all done over a text — simple, quick and seamless.

This adoption of conversational commerce reminds me of the early days of e-commerce. When I created some of the first direct-to-consumer websites early in my career, I can remember that our initial targets were to sell between 2 and 5 percent of our overall sales online — and that was considered a huge win! However, we will see text commerce proves to be faster and more convenient than e-commerce, when done well.

What is your business model — i.e., how does Whym make money?

Right now, we have a straightforward retail model. We produce our own product and buy product from other small instabrand (80 percent of our brands have less than 30,000 followers on Instagram). We sell those products for a profit. As we move into expanded offerings with our customers, there are multiple revenue streams that will result from our concierge and technology services.

What are you looking for when you select products for Whym, and what's your philosophy behind supporting smaller online brands?

Our product selection is unique in the fact that we cater to a career-focused woman. We encourage our team, our community and our customers to celebrate their femininity in the workplace, and to feel the freedom to bring their "whole" selves to work. You'll find a selection of products that help women dress up their desks and stock their work drawers and bags with everything they need to refresh during the day. In addition, we've added in "happy spends": flowers, coffee, socks, candles, etc. because ... why not?

We know what it's like to build a brand over the past two years amidst the changes in Instagram's algorithms (most posts only reach 6–8 percent of your followers) due to the backlash from bots and abuse by influencers and celebrities. In addition, Facebook advertising costs have skyrocketed. Brands are looking for meaningful ways to engage their communities without having an algorithm throttle their reach.

Having worked in the retail industry for the past 15 years, launching multiple brands in 40-plus countries across more than 20,000 points of sale, I also know the challenges of working with big-box retailers.

We want to champion small brands that share and face the same challenges we face. Our retail ecosystem provides a personal way to get to know about these products and ask questions. Our offline concepts give our customers and our brands a chance to meet each other in a physical space and experience products you would otherwise only see on a screen.

What inspired you to launch your own company in the first place?

As mentioned previously, I'm a busy, working mom! I only pay attention to text messages. And I wanted a company to use data and do more of the legwork on my shopping behavior.

What challenges did you encounter while building Whym and Petalfox?

Because our company moves so quickly, at this stage, we face small challenges every week. We face challenges of how to intelligently deploy capital to build our tech, outsource production and logistics, and reach our customers.

What learnings did you bring with you to Whym and Petalfox from your work at Snap?

Rhenee (my co-founder) and I brought with us our business relationship from Snap, which is one of the greatest strengths we have. We have a complimentary skill set that is

unparalleled. After almost five years working together, we will most likely be business partners for life.

Rhenee is perfectly suited to bring a startup to life. After working for agencies for most of her career, Rhenee became adept at taking grand ideas or concepts that were sold into big brands by agency executives, and architecting a plan to make them happen. In short, she's practiced making massive visions a physical reality.

Whym is now my seventh startup (but my first time founding a venture-capital-backed company). I've held executive roles in marketing, global sales and product development. I've launched 120 products in 40 physical countries, and most of all of these products have had some kind of emerging technology or breakthrough consumer behavior angle. Most notably, I launched the first consumer-grade drone in 2010 with a Parisian-based company, I worked on robots for four years, and I dreamt up the go-to-market strategy for Snapchat Spectacles.

How do you and your co-founder Rhenee Bartlett work together?

Block and tackle. I'm more art. She's more science. We were both born in the Midwest and simply come to the table with a work ethic that drives us to 200 percent on everything. We've both traveled the world several times over and share similar worldviews with almost opposite skill sets. I dream it; she brings it to life and makes it run smoothly. We're a match made in heaven.

What milestones do you aim to achieve in the next six months?

We are launching another small Gen Z brand to serve the demand of our 18-plus demographic who are the most interested in buying over text. We are expanding our personal shopping and concierge experiences. The next version of our technology will personalize our customer experience via our product recommendation engine and merchandising algorithms.

Is there a significance to Whym's text number 95479?

The five-digit text number was approved after a 100-day long approval process we underwent with all cell phone carriers in the U.S. It's the hallmark of a company that takes text commerce and conversational commerce seriously. This allows us to better serve our customers in a secure and authentic way, because this number has been specifically approved for Whym's use, messaging, marketing and commerce.

Our head of CX affectionately refers to our shortcode as 9-LIP-9.

What's behind the company's name?

Whym reflects the sentiment of our customers. The top key terms our customers use to describe the brand experience is "ease, simplicity and convenience." Using an emoji to make a happy spend is one of the quickest and most delightful experiences you'll have during your day!

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